

implemented Food Security for All, a programme to provide food for all poor families in the state. The government has set aside Rs. 945 crore annually on this scheme.

Setting aside the argument of experts regarding high cost of food subsidies, the Chief Minister has gone ahead with the scheme. His argument is that the cost of not subsidising food would be far greater and endure for generations.

As a doctor he knows that lack of a mere trace element (required in extremely low quantities) like iodine has caused a devastating impact on the health of tribals and other poor people. If that deficiency is related to staples like rice the impact can be as terrible as stunted growth, frequent illness and loss of valuable workdays. The decision was taken after weighing all the pros and cons.

The Chhattisgarh government's task was made even more difficult by the Centre's assumption that the number of Below Poverty Line (BPL) families in the state was only 18.75 lakh. State Govt. took a bold decision to include all those poor families who were considered below poverty line (in previous surveys since 1991), thus making the number of beneficiary to 36 lakhs families.

Another major burden has been caused by the Centre's drastic reduction of Above Poverty Line (APL) share of the state's rice allocation from 61005 metric tonnes to 953 metric tonnes, despite the fact that Chhattisgarh is among the few states which contribute so generously to the Central grain pool.

■ MONITORING

Fool proof ways have been devised to make the scheme successful. Making use of modern technology, the state has established call centres with toll-free numbers where anyone can lodge a complaint about the non-availability of rice and it is directly monitored by the food and civil supplies department. As soon as a truck leaves the godown for a particular village, the details of the carrier and quantity are SMSed to the sarpanch and responsible citizens of the area. The aim is to involve as many people as possible in the monitoring so that the chances of corruption are minimised. There are other methods as well, like fitting trucks with GPRS monitoring systems so that they do not stray from their path. Jan Bhagidari websites are some of the other methods of public monitoring.

Many people in India had an idea of the gigantic steps being taken by the Government of Chhattisgarh following a workshop on the Public Distribution System (PDS) earlier this year in Raipur. It was unique in the sense that for the first time it was attended enthusiastically by all the stakeholders of the system. The workshop was inaugurated by the Chief Minister, Dr. Raman Singh, and Justice D P Wadhwa, Chairperson of the Central Vigilance Committee on the PDS. Dr N C Saxena, Commissioner to the Supreme Court of India in the Right to Food Case highlighted the critical areas of concern in the PDS in India. Large number of people were being left out of PDS in India because poverty line has been set at unreasonably low level and there was a need to double the number of BPL families. He praised the efforts of the Chhattisgarh Government in improving the food security of the poorest households in the state.

Shri Nandkumar, Secretary to the Government of India, Ministry of Food and Public Distribution said that quality of

rice procured from Chhattisgarh was of very high quality and it is the second highest rice procurer in the country after Punjab.

Shri Prashant Mishra, Advocate General of Chhattisgarh highlighted that the state has successfully removed the private players who were the biggest beneficiaries and replaced them with panchayat's co-operative societies and other public bodies.

Justice Wadhwa stressed to strengthen the legal regime on the PDS and to go for complete computerization of the PDS.

Chief Minister Dr. Raman Singh proudly proclaimed that Chhattisgarh has already taken steps for total food security in the state on its own at a cost of 945 crore rupees a year. They are giving rice at 35 kg per month at Rs 3 per kg to 70% families in the state.



- Chief Minister Food Security Scheme provides 35 kg of rice per month to the poor families at the subsidised rate of Rs 3 per kg. This will benefit 36 lakh families, irrespective of the caste, creed or race.
- All poor families get 2 kg iodised salt at the rate of 25 paise per kg every month.
- All beneficiaries under the National Old Age Pension Scheme and Social Security Pension of the State Government get Rs 3 per kg rice per month.
- About 2000 Grain Banks and 5,500 fair price shops run entirely by women in remote areas.
- Every Gram Panchayat keeps one quintal rice to be distributed free of cost to the needy.
- Poor and needy people get full meal at Rs.5 at 177 centres run by NGO's which are assisted by the State Government.
- Toll free call centres have been set up for public grievance redressal in respect of public distribution system.
- Special ration cards with bar code to be provided to the beneficiaries.
- Two litres of kerosene distributed to every needy person on Haat Bazaar day without ration card.

